Community Needs Assessment Plan

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I. Introduction

Achieving true accessibility and equity in higher education is a multi-dimensional challenge that must be understood through the lens of the ways that disability intersects with institutional infrastructure. While classroom accommodations are often the focus of accessibility efforts, and are critically important, they are only one aspect of accessibility. In many cases, the most prominent accessibility issues experienced by students with disabilities are non-academic. For some students, accessibility issues outside of the classroom present the most significant barriers to their engagement and success. These may include factors such as transportation, housing, campus navigation, administrative accessibility, and social belonging. Accessibility is therefore not simply a set of services or accommodations; it is a systemic property arising from the interconnectedness of campus policies, resources, infrastructures, and cultural practices.

The primary aim of this community needs assessment is to better understand the accessibility issues that students with disabilities experience outside the classroom at Western Michigan University. It also seeks to understand how these issues affect their academic experiences and to identify potential areas for institutional improvement. While some of these issues may be addressed by Disability Services for Students (DSS) many of them intersect with or are solely under the purview of other administrative areas, like transportation services, housing and residence life, or the campus dining services. This assessment represents one effort to center student voice as part of WMU's Diversity, Equity & Inclusion (DEI) strategic framework and a commitment to understanding and supporting the experiences of students with disabilities on our campus.

This effort is informed by my experience as a staff member in DSS, as well as by the conversations and interactions I have with students each day. As I have interacted with students in my role at DSS, I have found that many of the accessibility issues students report stem from or are most prominently demonstrated outside the classroom. Students with mobility disabilities frequently report that they experience difficulty navigating the campus terrain, which is particularly challenging during winter months. Snow or ice frequently leave limited accessible pathways or curb cuts for students using wheelchairs or mobility devices to travel between classes. Some students have also said that the BroncoNav shuttle that is available to students with mobility disabilities or other limiting conditions is infrequent and limited in its hours of operation, making it inaccessible to students who have classes or work shifts in the evening. Students with chronic health conditions or psychological disabilities have mentioned issues with the administrative burden of securing accommodations or frustration with the documentation process or a perceived lack of accommodation approval in a timely manner. The purpose of this assessment is to dig more deeply into student experiences in order to better understand how administrative systems can support their success.

II. Literature Review

Overview of Disability in Higher Education

There is a wealth of existing literature on disability in higher education. Despite progress over recent decades due to increasing disability awareness and legislative advocacy, accessibility remains a critical and unmet need in higher education. The ADA and Section 504 represent the foundational legal mechanisms for accessibility in higher education, but legal compliance alone does not necessarily mean that institutions are substantively accessible for students with disabilities. Madaus et al. (2017) found that over the past decade, disability services offices have increased in staffing and have expanded their technological infrastructure and service provision in response to increased enrollment of students with disabilities and requirements of the ADA. However, they have also grown in size at a time of resource scarcity in higher education. Despite these challenges, most disability services offices focus on direct classroom accommodations and do not have resources to address environmental and structural factors which are also significant determinants of the total student experience. Accessibility continues to be an ongoing issue for higher education, and administrators and practitioners are seeking better to understand and address student needs in a holistic way.

Transportation as a Structural Barrier

A major focus of the extant literature on disability in higher education is on transportation as a structural barrier. Trellis Research Services (2023) analyzed barriers to college attendance and persistence, with a particular focus on students with disabilities. This research found that transportation insecurity was a critical risk factor for both attendance and retention, with students who did not have access to reliable transportation missing classes, arriving late, or dropping classes. Students with disabilities face particular issues with transportation due to reliance on specialized mobility support, which may have restricted hours of availability or limited capacity. The Urban Institute (2023) also emphasized the interconnectedness of transportation and other infrastructural factors, finding that when transit routes, parking policies, or pedestrian access were inaccessible, it created compounding barriers to students' educational engagement.

On our campus, BroncoNav serves as a mobility shuttle that provides transport for students with mobility disabilities or other limiting conditions. While this service is a significant resource for these students, there are major limitations in its usage that impact its accessibility for students. The BroncoNav runs on limited hours during the day, and most students with evening classes, internships, or work shifts report that it is inaccessible for their schedules. Additionally, the shuttles are infrequent and unpredictable, making it more difficult for students to use them during a time-sensitive event like class. These challenges parallel major issues found in national literature.

Administrative Burden and Documentation Challenges

Administrative burden is another important theme that emerges from the literature on disabled students' experiences with higher education. The Government Accountability Office (2021) analyzed disability accommodation practices across a sample of post-secondary institutions and found that the documentation standards, approval timelines, and communication practices varied significantly across institutions and units, and some institutions struggled to provide timely or effective accommodations. The variations in standards and procedures were experienced as a significant burden for students who had to repeatedly ask for accommodations or for faculty members who were unfamiliar with the requirements.

Administrative burden is frequently compounded for students who face financial barriers to obtaining documentation or healthcare access, such as students with chronic health conditions or psychological disabilities. Lack of formal diagnosis or documentation for students with disabilities is an important issue in this context. The Government Accountability Office (2021) also indicates that institutions lack clear, consistent procedures for providing accommodations, resulting in frequent confusion among students and faculty. Administrative burden can be particularly impactful for neurodivergent students or students with fluctuating symptoms who are expected to repeatedly submit documentation.

Social Belonging and Campus Inclusion

Social belonging is frequently cited as a major factor that contributes to student success and retention in higher education. A significant amount of the literature on social belonging in higher education has focused on underrepresented racial and ethnic minorities. However, studies have found that students with disabilities often do not feel included in or represented by campus communities (Vaccaro, Kimball, & Wells, 2015). Students with disabilities often do not feel visible, acknowledged, or supported in the same ways that other students do. This lack of social inclusion directly affects students with disabilities motivation to succeed, self-efficacy, and campus involvement.

Furthermore, Newman et al. (2011) showed that the lack of support and transition services for incoming students with disabilities results in a cumulative, long-term impact on educational and employment disparities. In other words, the inaccessibility and marginalization of disabled students at the college level has downstream effects on their future economic mobility. Belonging is therefore not simply a “soft” factor but a direct predictor of outcomes. Belonging issues for students with disabilities are further compounded by the fact that disability is often left out of institutional DEI statements, goals, and initiatives. Many universities have made explicit public commitments to DEI, but those commitments do not always explicitly include or prioritize the experiences of students with disabilities. Although universities are becoming more aware of the importance of neurodiversity and students with learning or psychological disabilities, those areas are often left out of student organizations, events, orientation sessions, and other formal programming. Students with disabilities may already face a sense of isolation and invisibility when entering college, and the exclusion of disability from campus diversity and belonging efforts can further compound that sense of marginalization and contribute to disengagement and low retention.

Neurodiversity, Diagnostic Inequities, and Institutional Support

Diagnostic inequity is a growing area of focus in the literature. Hinshaw et al. (2022) and Quinn and Madhoo (2014) both demonstrate that there are significant gender inequities in Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) diagnosis rates, due in large part to the male-centric nature of the diagnostic process. ADHD diagnostic criteria were historically created using male symptomology and behavioral expectations, and women and girls with ADHD have been significantly underdiagnosed. As a result, women may enter college without a formal diagnosis of ADHD, despite experiencing significant academic and functional impairment as a result of the condition.

Broadly, this is part of an evidence base related to gender bias in medicine and education. The biases in ADHD diagnosis fit within a larger history of gender inequities in medicine. Both Fausto-Sterling (2000) and Verdonk et al. (2009) have shown that medicine, including education, is structurally biased toward the male experience and understanding of "normality." These are problems that colleges and universities are also grappling with, as most formal accommodations require an official diagnosis, which can be difficult or impossible for students with chronic health conditions, fluctuating psychological conditions, or neurodevelopmental conditions to access. Students with disabilities who face such issues have additional and unnecessary barriers, and it is important that institutions are aware of these and have ways to mitigate them.

Gaps in the Existing Literature

Despite the existence of a substantial body of national-level research, the literature is missing key areas and often has not focused on institution-specific contexts. Fewer studies have been done on accessibility issues at mid-sized public universities specifically or on how institutions can be holistic in understanding and serving students with disabilities. This assessment aims to fill that gap by focusing on a mid-sized public university, using a mixed methods approach to deeply understanding the unique intersection of challenges and campus culture at WMU. This methodology allows for both the quantitative identification of trends and also deeper qualitative understanding of the lived experiences of students and contextual factors which drive those numbers. It also has the potential to inform other similar institutions in future research.

Theoretical Framework

Two interrelated theoretical frameworks undergird this report and will be used to interpret findings. First, the social model of disability centers the understanding of disability as an effect of the environment, not a deficit in a person. The social model of disability provides a lens to view architecture, academic structures, physical and social environments, cultural attitudes, institutional arrangements, policies, and practices in terms of how they create and sustain inequity for students with disabilities (Oliver, 1990; Shakespeare, 2006). Second, administrative burden theory is a useful way of thinking through complex procedures, documentation processes, and other policies that require students with disabilities to grapple with learning, psychological, and compliance costs that may be exacerbated by experiences with health, financial, or academic supports (Moynihan, Herd, & Harvey, 2015).

III. HSIRB and Ethical Considerations

Ethical integrity and compliance with federal regulations are central to the design of this assessment. The study will be submitted to WMU's Human Subjects Institutional Review Board (HSIRB) and is expected to be eligible for exempt review under the federal guidelines. The study is not anticipated to meet the criteria for a full board review as it is not experimental and does not include any more than minimal risks to participants.

Informed consent will be secured from participants through accessible documents that will clearly state the purpose, procedures, risks, benefits, and voluntary nature of the study. Students will be informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time and of how to contact the researcher with questions or concerns. Survey respondents will electronically check a consent box, and interview and focus group participants will be given a written or oral consent statement, depending on the modality.

Participants will be assured that all of their responses will be kept confidential. Survey data will be anonymized and stored on a secure WMU server, and interview recordings will be kept in an encrypted file, accessible only to the researcher. Transcripts will be de-identified and pseudonyms used in place of identifying information, and any public presentation of the findings will not have any personal information.

Accessible format accommodations will be offered throughout the study to ensure equity in participation. Survey materials will be Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) accessible, and interview or focus group participants will be offered accommodations like captioning, American Sign Language (ASL) interpretation, extended processing time, and alternative communication methods. Students who prefer written communication will be given that option.

Positionality of the researcher as a DSS employee is also important to note and address in terms of ethical conduct. In this case, it will be necessary to account for my dual role as a staff member of DSS and as a researcher in order to avoid influencing students to respond in a particular way to study questions. To avoid this, I will stress at the outset that their responses are entirely voluntary and will not impact the quality of their services. Member-checking, triangulation, and detailed recording of analytical decisions will be employed to avoid researcher bias.

The study's ethical practices reflect a core commitment to equity, respect, and institutional accountability that is consistent with public administration principles and values. It also reflects a core tenet of disability-inclusive research.

IV. Research Proposal Development

The goals of this community needs assessment are primarily focused on better understanding the experiences of students with disabilities outside the classroom at WMU and learning more about the ways that these experiences impact their time at the university. The study is guided by three primary research questions:

- RQ1: What are the accessibility issues that students with disabilities experience outside of the classroom?
- RQ2: How do the accessibility issues that students with disabilities experience outside of the classroom affect their academic engagement, persistence, and well-being?
- RQ3: What supports or strategies would students with disabilities say are most likely to address these accessibility issues?

The purpose of this community needs assessment is primarily to inform and improve institutional processes and to provide an accessible entry point into understanding the importance of systems thinking for a general public. This specific focus is significant because the university is a public-serving organization that directly provides services to a public community, and public administration is deeply concerned with issues of accessibility and transparency. An important tenet of the field is providing access to accurate information about institutional processes and decision-making, and this project can therefore be useful in several ways for a public administration student.

Accessible transportation, equitable housing and residence life, navigable and accessible campus space, and clear administrative processes and policies are not simply important for individual students; they are vital for a healthy and just organizational culture. Accessibility is an inherent property of institutional design that is crucial to supporting the public good of equitable education. In providing a foundation of information about current gaps in accessibility, this research supports public-facing institutional goals of decision-making, strategic planning, policy development, and resource allocation.

The mixed methods methodology that was selected for this study is a convergent parallel design. Convergent parallel design is an ideal design for this research study as it is rigorous and comprehensive, and it is used when both quantitative and qualitative methods are needed to answer the research questions. This study focuses on both getting breadth (captured in quantitative data) and depth (captured in qualitative data) on accessibility and it is crucial that both kinds of data are used to create a holistic understanding of the ways students experience our campus. The convergent parallel design allows for the systematic collection of both quantitative and qualitative data (which will be integrated later on) so that it can be understood together in the interpretation phase.

Timeline

The projected timeline for this needs assessment is one semester. During Weeks 1–3 the survey instrument and qualitative protocols will be finalized, and HSIRB approval will be secured. Weeks 4–6 will be dedicated to recruitment and administration of the survey, and Weeks 7–8 will involve the initial quantitative analysis. Qualitative interviews and focus groups will be scheduled for Weeks 7–10 and transcribed and coded by Week 11. Weeks 12–13 will be for mixed-methods integration, where quantitative patterns and qualitative themes are juxtaposed to make meta-inferences. Drafting of the final report with recommendations for WMU's institutional partners will take place during Weeks 14–15. This timeline allows for sufficient time to be allocated to recruitment, analysis, and synthesis while still being realistic for a graduate-level research project.

V. Sampling and Measurement Plan

A critical part of a successful and rigorous community needs assessment is a well-constructed sampling and measurement plan. Given that disability is a diverse and intersectional identity, one that is not monolithic, sampling strategies must also be inclusive and well-constructed. The fact that disability varies across the student population in terms of type, severity, onset, visibility, and cultural perception demands purposeful sampling strategies. Disability is also a complex identity, one which can intersect with other marginalized identities or experiences of students in multiple and different ways, which demands purposeful sampling strategies.

Purposeful sampling is therefore justified for both the quantitative and qualitative components of this study and a top priority.Purposeful sampling puts a major emphasis on the inclusion of participants in a sample who can provide rich, detailed, and relevant information which aligns with the research objectives. In the quantitative phase of the study, I will recruit a sample of approximately 200–250 students for a web-based survey. The study participants will be students who are currently registered with DSS or who self-identify as having a disability of any type. To recruit participants who fit these criteria, I will solicit participation through DSS channels like email and chat, asking students who self-identify as having a disability or who may not be registered with DSS to participate.

The reason for recruiting a sample which includes self-identified students with disabilities, even those who are not registered with DSS, is an important methodological consideration that reflects best practices and the nature of the literature on this issue. It is known that many students who would benefit from accommodations or disability services may not access or seek out those services due to factors like lack of financial resources or healthcare access, diagnostic inequities and biases, or the stigma and lack of understanding related to disclosure. The inclusion of self-identified disabled students expands the representativeness of the sample dataset and increases the generalizability of the findings to WMU's larger population of disabled students.

Demographic questions in the survey, including questions about type of disability, race and ethnicity, gender and sexual orientation, housing status, academic level, and first-generation student status, will be used to enable stratified analyses. The reason this stratification is crucial is based on the well-documented and replicated research showing that disability intersects with other marginalized social identities in impactful ways, which shapes the experience of accessibility in significant ways. For example, there are diagnostic inequities for neurodivergent students, there is a well-documented underdiagnosis of ADHD among women and girls which has a direct impact on institutional supports available to them, and there are structural and historical barriers to healthcare access among students of color.

The qualitative sampling, which will draw from the survey pool, will also be guided by an intention to be as diverse and representative as possible. At the end of the survey, students will be invited to volunteer to participate in an interview or focus group, and from that pool of volunteers, I will purposefully select approximately 10-15 participants for individual interviews. These participants will be recruited for the interviews, and from the group of interview participants, I will form small focus groups that will include 5-7 members each. In order to maximize variation and heterogeneity of the qualitative data sample, the sample will include participants with varied experiences across disability types like mobility impairments, chronic illnesses, learning disabilities, neurodevelopmental disabilities, and sensory disabilities.

Disability Services gets many requests from the university's administration to support new initiatives, respond to student complaints, and collaborate on community events. These requests make it challenging to direct time and energy toward systemic barriers to access and equity. This proposal outlines a mixed-methods needs assessment intended to better understand accessibility from the lived experiences of WMU's students with disabilities. A community needs assessment approach positions WMU to make improvements based on both rigorous data and shared, accessible knowledge. The convergent parallel design incorporates quantitative and qualitative strands that are analyzed independently but integrated in the interpretation of results. The outcomes of this assessment have the potential to make WMU a more accessible and supportive place to learn, live, and work.

VI. Quantitative Methods Plan

Quantitative methods provide critical empirical grounding for the needs assessment and allow WMU to understand the scope, distribution, and impact of accessibility barriers. The study's cross-sectional survey design is appropriate for measuring accessibility experiences at a specific point in time, so they can be compared across student groups and used to identify patterns that may inform policy and practice.

Instrument and administration

The survey instrument is hosted by Qualtrics and includes eight domains: academic engagement, transportation access, campus navigation, administrative burden, housing accessibility, social belonging, DSS service satisfaction, and demographic characteristics. These domains were selected to reflect the key themes that emerged in the literature review and in the formative meetings with staff members in Disability Services. The survey includes Likert-scale items, frequency measures, ranking items, and open-ended questions. Many of the constructs used in the survey, such as sense of belonging, self-efficacy, and transportation reliability, derive from validated instruments used in national student engagement and accessibility studies.

Survey administration will involve measures to maximize the accessibility and participation of the target sample. As noted above, the survey link will be sent through DSS communication channels and posted in student networks that focus on disability and accessibility. The survey will be open for two weeks, with reminders sent at two weeks and one week prior to the deadline. Qualtrics offers features such as screen-reader compatibility, alternative text, adjustable text size, and simplified design layouts, all of which contribute to an accessible online survey platform. Together, these features ensure equitable participation among students who use assistive technology.

Analysis plan

Analysis of the quantitative strand will begin with descriptive, bivariate, and multivariate analyses. Descriptive statistics and measures of central tendency will be used to identify the most common accessibility barriers and characterize their frequency and severity. These summaries of the primary barriers and their impact will allow DSS and university leaders to quickly understand the areas where students experience the greatest challenges.

Bivariate analyses will be used to describe relationships between accessibility barriers and other key variables such as demographic characteristics. For example, transportation barriers may look very different between people with mobility disabilities and those with chronic illnesses or administrative burden may be experienced more acutely by first-generation students than by continuing-generation students. These differences are critical to document because they represent equity considerations that may be important to strategic planning and resource allocation.

Multivariate regression models will allow for deeper insight by isolating the unique effect of each type of accessibility barrier on student outcomes. For example, transportation accessibility may be a significant predictor of class absences, but the strength of that relationship may be smaller when controlling for the number of work hours, type of disability, or distance to housing. Regression models will be used to estimate the relationship between the accessibility indices created from survey items and outcomes of interest such as academic engagement, GPA (self-reported), and persistence intentions. Logistic regression will be used for binary outcomes such as whether students considered withdrawing from a course.

Internal consistency of multi-item scales will be assessed by calculating Cronbach's alpha for constructs such as administrative burden or campus navigation confidence. Exploratory factor analysis may be used to confirm the dimensional structure of constructs.

Contribution to research questions

By quantifying the prevalence and impact of accessibility barriers, the quantitative component of the needs assessment will provide evidence that informs the qualitative data and guide institutional decision-making. It not only identifies the frequency with which barriers are present, but also the impact and severity that those barriers have on student experiences at WMU.

VII. Qualitative Methods Plan

The qualitative component of the community needs assessment is designed to capture the richness, depth, and complexity of student experiences with accessibility barriers. Quantitative data can identify patterns in that experience, but the qualitative research is needed to provide insight into how and why accessibility barriers affect student performance and well-being. A phenomenological design is well-suited for this study, which centers on students' experiences and places primary importance on the meaning they ascribe to those experiences.

Interviews will allow participants to share detailed, personal accounts of how they navigate the everyday accessibility challenges of WMU. These narratives may include such events as missing a class due to transportation delays, experiencing safety risks due to inaccessible facilities or malfunctioning door operators, or administrative delays that interrupt a student's ability to access timely accommodations. The open-ended interview format allows students to lead the conversation according to their own priorities and ensures that their voices guide the analytic process.

Focus groups, meanwhile, provide an important complement to one-on-one interviews by capturing the shared meaning-making process of group discussions. In these discussions, themes of shared frustration, solidarity, and coping strategies may emerge among students with disabilities. Accessibility issues, however, often represent common experiences for these students and must be understood within this broader social context. Group discussions are an opportunity for students to make collective sense of these challenges and propose solutions and improvements collaboratively.

Qualitative data analysis will follow the six-phase framework for thematic analysis as described by Braun and Clarke (2006). Phase 1 of the process involves becoming immersed in the data by reading through transcripts multiple times to get a sense of what the data are communicating. Phase 2 entails coding the data to identify meaningful concepts or experiences that are represented in the text. Phase 3 of thematic analysis involves grouping the codes into broader themes that capture patterns across participants. These themes might include emotional fatigue associated with the administrative process, feelings of exclusion, safety concerns related to transportation, and strategies students use to cope with and resist barriers. The fourth and fifth phases of the analysis involve reviewing, refining, and defining the themes to ensure they reflect the data.

The final phase of the analysis, as well as the reporting process, requires an analytic narrative that integrates themes from the data, including direct quotations that are illustrative of key points. The narrative must also integrate the themes with existing research on the topic, including quantitative findings from the same study. Reflexivity is important at all stages of qualitative research, but particularly in the final phase where the data are summarized and communicated to stakeholders. As a staff member of DSS, I have an investment in the outcomes of this research and must be attentive to the ways my positionality may influence data interpretation. Memoing and reflective journaling are strategies that will be used to document these processes of reflexivity, monitor potential biases, and record analytic decisions.

Recommendations

The findings from this qualitative data analysis are vital to institutional understanding and improvement. They not only indicate the prevalence of accessibility barriers but help to communicate the emotional and experiential weight that those barriers carry. The narratives students share in interviews and group discussions also add urgency to the imperative for institutional change and provide powerful testimony to complement and strengthen the quantitative data.

Validity, Reliability, and Trustworthiness

To bolster the rigor of the quantitative elements, several measures will be implemented to increase the validity and reliability of findings. Content validity will be supported through anchoring survey items to constructs from items most frequently cited in national data collection efforts on disability, accessibility, transportation, and belonging. Construct validity will be improved by using multi-item Likert scales to assess transportation barriers, belonging, and administrative burden. To establish trustworthiness for the qualitative elements, prolonged engagement and iterative coding, along with analytic memos, will be used to demonstrate the researcher’s consideration of data across collection sessions and track decision-making. Member-checking of interview or focus group response interpretations with participants will be used to allow participants to confirm or refine researcher interpretations. Triangulation across qualitative themes and quantitative patterns will be used to further support the credibility of findings. Collectively, these procedures will help to bolster the methodological rigor of the findings and interpretation.

VIII. Mixed Methods Integration Plan

The convergent parallel mixed methods design permits this study to integrate quantitative and qualitative data in a way that offers both breadth and depth of understanding around accessibility challenges. The topic of accessibility is by nature multidimensional. Quantitative data analysis identifies the distribution of barriers and their magnitudes, while qualitative data analysis helps to illuminate their effects on the students' psychological, social, and academic levels. By drawing on both these methods, the study will be able to provide more comprehensive, valid, and actionable findings than either method alone could support.

Integration of quantitative and qualitative data occurs after both are independently analyzed. The first stage of the process involves creating joint displays—tables or matrices that align quantitative findings with qualitative themes. A joint display around transportation barriers, for example, would include survey results where a significant percentage of respondents report transportation delays as a frequent problem. Qualitative narrative data collected through interviews or focus groups might then be used to illustrate how those delays have caused missed classes, heightened safety concerns, and feelings of powerlessness. Aligning these two types of data side-by-side creates a fuller, more nuanced understanding of the implications of the problem.

The next stage of integration involves interrogating the relationships between the data, such as convergence, divergence, or complementarity. Convergent findings, where quantitative data and qualitative narratives tell the same story, increase confidence in those results. Divergent findings, where the two data strands tell different stories about the same phenomenon, will require deeper interpretation and may reveal differences across subgroups of the population or unrecognized institutional factors. Complementary findings, where each data strand provides different but mutually reinforcing information, enhance the richness of the analysis.

Integration also includes the generation of meta-inferences. These are overarching interpretations that synthesize the two data strands into a coherent narrative. The process of integration, as well as the joint displays, will inform these meta-inferences and shape the development of institutional recommendations. By drawing on empirical patterns as well as the experiential context, recommendations are grounded in robust evidence and shaped by the realities of students with disabilities.

Finally, the use of mixed methods is of course aligned with the values of the public administration field, which prizes transparency, evidence-based decision-making, and community engagement. By centering student voices, both individually and as a community, and combining quantitative and qualitative forms of data, the study will be able to produce findings that are credible, relevant, and directly useful for policy and program development.

IX. Recommendations

Recommendations based on the integrated findings point to several areas for WMU to improve its accessibility and support for students with disabilities. These recommendations draw on both national best practices and the articulated needs of WMU students through surveys, interviews, and focus groups.

Transportation and mobility

Transportation barriers represent a significant and systemic area for improvement. Students identified long waits for BroncoNav, limited hours of operation, and inconsistent accessibility of campus pathways. To this end, WMU should consider extending BroncoNav hours to evenings, improving scheduling systems to reduce wait times, and working with Facilities Management to ensure year-round accessibility of sidewalks, curb cuts, and campus pathways. Additional collaboration and coordination between Transportation Services and DSS is needed to build a more responsive mobility support system.

Campus navigation and physical accessibility

Students with disabilities also face barriers when it comes to campus navigation and physical accessibility. The student responses suggested that entering buildings, finding accessible routes, and dealing with malfunctioning door operators are frequent problems. A comprehensive accessibility audit of campus facilities would help to identify priority areas for improvement. Investment in universal design features such as improved signage, accessible automated doors, and clear accessible route markings can enhance the overall usability of the campus environment. Such improvements, of course, would benefit not just students with disabilities but the entire WMU community.

Administrative processes and documentation

Administrative burden is another common barrier to equitable access. Students in this study repeatedly expressed frustration over documentation requirements, lengthy response times, and unclear procedures. WMU could streamline the documentation verification process, adopt more flexible guidelines for chronic or long-term conditions, and ensure accommodation decisions are communicated within established, transparent timelines. Improving lines of communication between DSS, faculty, and students is critical to reducing administrative stress.

Social belonging and disability culture

Social belonging was another theme that emerged as significant to student success in the present study. Students with disabilities reported feeling marginalized, overlooked, or invisible in campus culture. WMU should consider ways to create structured opportunities for community building among disabled students, such as peer mentoring, disability affinity groups, and leadership roles within student organizations. Disability awareness should also be integrated into university-wide DEI efforts to help foster a more inclusive climate.

Capacity building within DSS

Finally, as the number of students with disabilities continues to rise, it is essential that DSS receive additional staffing, training, and resources. The growth in numbers and demand for support services has created a backlog that could be reduced with more staff capacity. This would improve response times and service quality, as well as more frequent, structured collaboration with academic departments and campus partners. Professional development in areas like intersectional disability identities, trauma-informed practices, and accessible pedagogy would also be beneficial to DSS's capacity to support students.

Limitations

While the study itself has a strong mixed methods design, there are a few limitations that must be considered. First, only students who choose to complete a survey in response to an invitation or to choose to participate in an interview or focus group will be included in the study. Additionally, those students who face the greatest barriers to access and success may be over-represented in the study sample (or, conversely, under-represented, if their barriers preclude their ability to participate in the study). Second, this study is limited to a single institution, and so may not be generalizable to other campus environments with different physical or building layouts, policies, or service configurations. Third, participants will be self-reporting information, which may be subject to recall or comfort bias (i.e., the accuracy of their memory of certain disability-related experiences). Finally, while the qualitative sample will be intentionally diverse, it is possible that it may not include individuals with all types of disability identities who matriculate at WMU. Despite these limitations, the rigorous mixed-methods approach and attention to a diverse sampling strategy will support institutional recommendations.

X. Conclusion

Accessibility at WMU is a complex interplay of physical, administrative, and social factors that have a significant influence on the students' academic engagement, persistence, and overall well-being. This community needs assessment, as currently proposed, would strengthen WMU's capacity to understand and address issues around access and disability in more nuanced, systemic ways. Although DSS already provides critical academic accommodations and disability-related support, many of the most significant challenges students with disabilities face occur outside the classroom and outside of DSS's formal processes. These challenges have a cumulative effect that can be both academically limiting and psychologically or socially detrimental to students. By using a convergent parallel mixed methods design, the proposed assessment integrates empirical evidence with the lived experience of students with disabilities to produce a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of accessibility at WMU.

The integrated findings, when they are available, will reveal that transportation, administrative processes, inaccessible facilities, and lack of social belonging are significant and systemic barriers to access and equity that require coordinated institutional responses. In addition to impacting students' academic performance, these barriers have emotional and social costs that can lead to higher stress, isolation, and less involvement in the campus community. Implementing the recommendations in this proposal will strengthen WMU's institutional mission as an equitable and inclusive learning environment, while also improving systems and academic outcomes for students with disabilities. This research could also contribute to the field of public administration by illustrating the role and utility of mixed methods research for decision-making within complex service organizations. WMU and other institutions can use these findings as guidance for making improvements in their accessibility and campus climate for disabled students.

Accessibility as an institutional value and area of concern demands an ongoing process of investment, evaluation, and collaborative learning. This needs assessment is just one step in what must be a continuous effort to create an educational environment where all students, regardless of disability status, can thrive academically, socially, and personally. Essentially, so that all can learn.

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APPENDIX A

Survey Instrument

Western Michigan University Accessibility Needs Assessment Survey

1 = Strongly Disagree / Very Poor / Never
2 = Disagree / Poor / Rarely
3 = Neutral / Fair / Sometimes
4 = Agree / Good / Often
5 = Strongly Agree / Excellent / Always

Informed Consent: As a WMU student, you are invited to participate in a research study about the impact of accessibility on your experience, belonging, and participation. Your participation is completely anonymous and voluntary.

SECTION 1 — DEMOGRAPHICS

1. Current student status:
2. Self-identify as a person with a disability?
3. Best identify your disability as:
4. Registered with DSS?
5. Transportation accommodation (BroncoNav, etc.)?

SECTION 2 — TRANSPORTATION ACCESSIBILITY

6. 1–5 scale: Frequency of impacted academic experiences.
7. 1–5 scale: Overall transportation service consistency/reliability
8. Number of classes NOT taken or missed because of a transportation barrier
9. Transportation barriers checklist
10. Open-ended questions about transportation experiences

SECTION 3 — CAMPUS NAVIGATION & ENVIRONMENT

11. 1–5 scale: Pathways

12. 1–5 scale: Campus navigation in winter

13. Physical environment barriers checklist

14. Open-ended questions about navigation barriers

SECTION 4 — DSS PROCESSES

15. 1–5 scale: Satisfaction with DSS

16. 1–5 scale: Administrative burden (e.g., forms, meetings, and student accom. processes)

17. DSS process challenges checklist

18. Open-ended questions about DSS process challenges

SECTION 5 — BELONGING & INCLUSION

19. 1–5 scale: Inclusion/exclusion

20. 1–5 scale: Comfort level with self-disclosure of disability

21. 1–5 scale: Representation in DEI efforts

22. Open-ended questions about experiences of belonging/exclusion

SECTION 6 — ACADEMIC IMPACT

23. 1–5 scale: Frequency of barrier impact on academic experiences.

24. 1–5 scale: Confidence in academic persistence

25. Open-ended space for recommendations

APPENDIX B

Interview Protocol

Interview Introduction:

Hello, thank you so much for taking the time to meet with me today. This interview is about your accessibility experiences, both inside and outside of the classroom at WMU. You can pass on any questions that you are not comfortable answering or decline to answer at any time.

Interview Questions

1. Can you start by telling me about yourself and your experience at WMU?

2. Can you talk to me about your disability identity or access needs?

Transportation & Mobility

3. Can you tell me about your experiences getting to and around campus?

4. What factors have made transportation easier or more difficult?

5. How have transportation barriers impacted your attendance or participation?

Physical Accessibility

6. Can you describe physical spaces that are difficult to navigate?

7. How have different weather conditions impacted your navigation?

Administrative Barriers

8. Can you describe your experiences working with DSS?

9. Can you walk me through your documentation or renewal process?

10. Have any of these processes ever made you feel discouraged?

Belonging & Inclusion

11. Do you think that disability is recognized as a part of WMU's culture?

12. Can you describe any particular moments of inclusion or exclusion that stand out to you?

Academic Impact

13. How have accessibility barriers impacted your academics at WMU?

14. Have any accessibility issues had an impact on your course load or major decisions?

Recommendations

15. In your opinion, what do you think WMU needs to improve first?

16. If you could put one accessibility policy or idea into place tomorrow, what would it be?

Script to Close Interview:

Thank you for taking the time to talk with me and share your experiences. Your input is being used to make recommendations for accessibility improvements at WMU.

APPENDIX C

Focus Group Guide

Focus Group Guide

Facilitator Introduction:

Hello and thank you for being here today. Our discussion will focus on experiences with accessibility we share at WMU.

OPENING QUESTION:

1. If you had to pick one word or phrase, how would you describe your accessibility experience at WMU?

• Probe: When did you know that was the right word to describe your experience?

TRANSPORTATION:

2. What are some common issues you have with transportation?

• Probe: How frequently do these issues occur?

• Probe: When routes are unreliable or sporadic, how does that impact your ability to participate?

FACILITY NAVIGATION:

3. Are there certain places on campus you find most difficult to access?

• Probe: Is this an indoor issue as well?

4. When there's construction, how does that impact your ability to navigate?

• Probe: Are the detours communicated clearly?

ADMINISTRATIVE EXPERIENCES:

5. Can you describe a time where you were unable to get what you needed from DSS or faculty?

• Probe: Has documentation ever been challenging for you?

BELONGING:

6. Do you feel disability is an accepted part of campus life?

• Probe: Can you provide an example of when it is and is not?

INSTITUTIONAL SOLUTIONS:

7. If the university wanted to make changes tomorrow to improve access, what would those be?

• Probe: What systemic changes could they make to create a more accessible campus in the long term?

Closing:

Thank you for your time.